


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

# ALL FOR A SAFE HOUSE

**Maharashtra chief minister Eknath Shinde has not only taken Uddhav Thackeray's chair but also lessons from the Shiv Sena chief's experience. Shinde has reportedly told confidants that he won't be moving into 'Varsha', the official chief ministerial residence in tony Malabar Hill. He will, instead, stay on in his present government accommodation, 'Nandanvan'. Shinde had used his own resources to make the house vastu-compliant after it was allotted to him in 2014 in his capacity as leader of the opposition. Interestingly, no incumbent barring Devendra Fadnavis has completed a term in office while living in 'Varsha'. The CM's aversion, though, is restricted to living in 'Varsha', not to holding official meetings there.**

## Insider/ Outsider




ANI

With their limited knowledge of Bengali, the BJP in West Bengal seems to have unwittingly played into chief minister Mamata Banerjee's hands. The party is calling its new outreach programme, which will see central leaders descend in batches to fortify 'weak' constituencies in the state till the 2024 general election, 'Prabash', or foreign land. This makes them *prabashis*, from whom Didi wants to save her state.

## RETURN JOURNEY

When in trouble, reshuffle. That's what Kerala chief minister **Pinarayi Vijayan** seems to be doing as he changes the top order in the state police. K. Padmakumar, additional DGP of the armed police battalion, will return to the ADGP headquarters. He replaces Manoj Abraham, who has been transferred as director, vigilance and anti-corruption bureau. Padmakumar, a 1989-batch IPS officer faced charges of sexual harassment by solar scam accused Saritha Nair. Many suspect Pinarayi's political secretary P. Sasi's role in his elevation. The CM is also looking out for a DGP as state police chief Anil Kant, whose tenure is till June 2023, is said to be seeking early retirement.



RATHEESH SUNDARAM

–Kaushik Deka *with Kiran D. Tare, Jeemon Jacob, Amarnath K. Menon and Romita Datta*



## THE NEW CHALLENGER

**Eatala Rajender**, 58, whom Telangana chief minister K. Chandrashekar Rao sacked as finance minister in May 2021 but did not expel from the Telangana Rashtra Samithi, is coming back to bite. He resigned as MLA in June 2021 to contest the Huzurabad bypoll on a BJP ticket and won by a big margin. He now heads the party's poaching panel ahead of the 2023 state polls. Last heard, he is preparing to take on KCR in Gajwel, the seat from where the latter began his political journey as the CM.

## Pride & Politics

Come September-October, and Gujarat will be hosting the 36th National Games in six cities. Meant to be held in the same months in Goa in 2020, the pandemic had put paid to the endeavour. The venue has now been shifted to Gujarat as Goa already has a BJP government now, and it's Gujarat that goes to polls in December. Hosting the games, for the first time ever, should earn the state some political mileage and add ballast to its slogan—*'Jai Jai Garvi Gujarat* (Victory to proud Gujarat)'—before the polls.